

PROGRAM OVERVIEW • 2025

GreenRoots Youth Corps

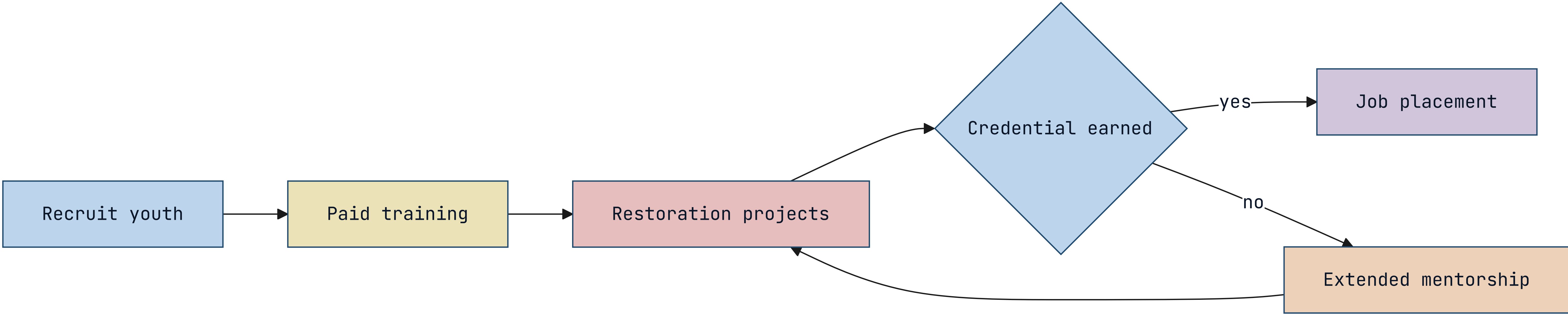
A paid pathway from the Cedar River banks to a green-collar career, for youth the labor market left behind.

We pay young people to restore the Cedar River — and train them into green jobs.

GreenRoots is a 16-week paid program for youth ages 16–24 in Cedar Rapids' East River neighborhoods. Crews restore habitat across the watershed while earning a wage, certifications, and a direct line to hiring partners.

- Participants earn \$16/hour from their first day in the field.
- The work is real: erosion control, native planting, trail repair under contract.

Our theory of change, from intake to a green career.



A participant's path through the program.

STEP 01

Recruit

Outreach through high schools and reentry partners brings youth into a paid four-week orientation.

STEP 02

Train

Twelve weeks of field training in habitat restoration, chainsaw and first-aid certs, and job-readiness coaching.

STEP 03

Work

Crews complete real restoration contracts across the Cedar River watershed, earning a wage and a portfolio.

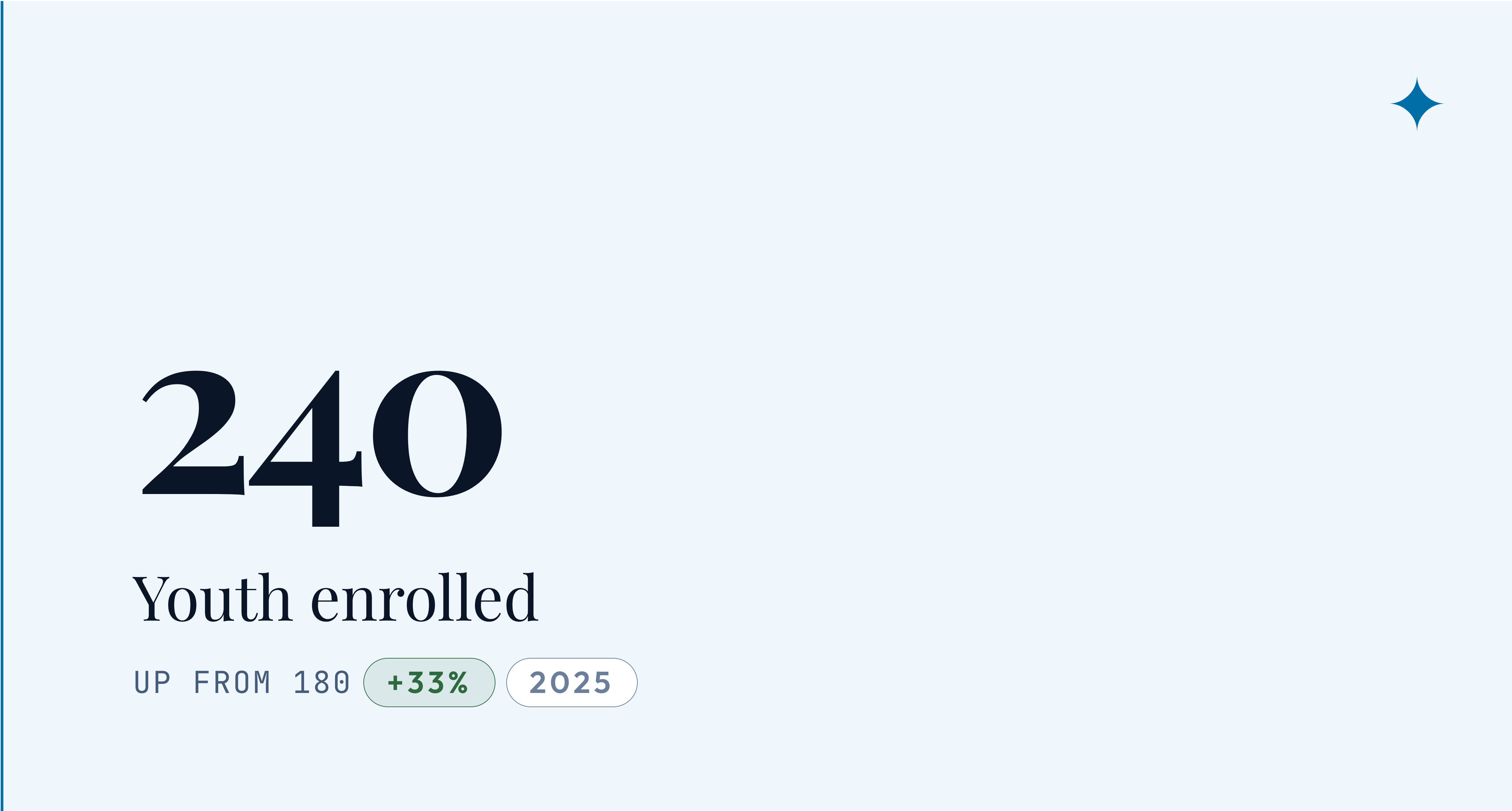
STEP 04

Place

Case managers match graduates to employer partners or post-secondary programs and check in for a year.

OUTCOMES • 2025

More youth enrolled, and more left with a job or a school seat.



78%

Placed or in school

TARGET 70% **ON PLAN** VERIFIED

91%

Credential earned

OF THOSE WHO FINISHED **ON PLAN**
AUDITED

Who we serve, and who delivers the program.

Youth participants

Ages 16–24

240 young people from the East River neighborhoods, paid \$16/hr while they train.

Program staff

GreenRoots team

Eight crew leaders and two case managers run daily restoration work and aftercare.

Employer partners

14 partners

Parks departments, utilities, and landscaping firms that hire our graduates directly.

“

I'd been kicked out of two schools before this. Out here I learned I could lead a crew. Now I run a parks team and I'm back in night classes.

”

— Devon Reyes, 2025 graduate, GreenRoots Youth Corps

THE EARNINGS STORY BEHIND A PLACEMENT

\$18,600

average annual earnings for a placed
graduate one year out — first steady
income for most.

IMPACT • 2025

A single season of restoration, by the numbers.



Recruitment reaches the young people other programs miss.

We draw enrollees from Cedar Rapids' three highest-unemployment neighborhoods. Two reentry organizations, the public library, and four high schools drive most qualified referrals into the program.

- 61% of the 240 enrollees came from those priority neighborhoods.
- 44% had a prior justice-system contact; 29% were not enrolled in school at intake.

The work itself is the curriculum.

Crews spend their days on contracted restoration — removing invasive honeysuckle, planting native buffers, and stabilizing eroded banks along the Cedar River. The wage and the certifications come from doing real work, not simulations.

- Field days are paired with two afternoons a week of certs and job-readiness coaching.
- Every graduate leaves with a portfolio of completed restoration sites.

EQUITY • 2025

The program reaches and keeps the youth it sets out to serve.



44%

Prior justice contact

RE-ENGAGED THROUGH WORK

ON PLAN

TRACKED

83%

Completion rate

FINISHED ALL 16 WEEKS

ON PLAN

AUDITED

COST • 2025

Public dollars stretch further than a year of incarceration.

All figures from audited spend over 240 enrollees and 187 placements.



Two things ran harder than planned this year.

A spring flood closed three worksites for five weeks, compressing the field calendar. Our fall cohort enrolled 52 against a 70-seat plan after a bus-route cut stranded referrals.

- We recovered field hours by extending contracts into the dry early-winter weeks.
- A transit stipend restored the next cohort to full size.

THE PLAN • 2026-2028

Where the next three seasons take the Corps.

WORKSTREAM	NOW	BUILD	SCALE
	2025	2026	2027
Youth served	✓ 240	– 320	○ 450
Hiring partners	✓ 14	– 22	○ 30
Watersheds	✓ Cedar	– +Iowa River	○ +Wapsipinicon
Certifications	✓ 3	– +Arborist	○ +Water quality

✓ Shipped

– In flight

○ Planned

We are ready to grow — and we are asking partners to grow with us.

The model holds: 240 youth served, 78% placed or in school, 84 cents of every dollar reaching participants. We are inviting funders and employers to help extend the Corps to a second watershed in 2026.

- A second site would add 80 paid seats and eight new hiring partners.
- Every expansion dollar is matched by contracted restoration revenue.

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Pay a young person to heal a
river, and you get back both
a watershed and a worker.